night, it didn't matter. In those years, after joining the school team, cricket became everything for me. I prayed that I'd keep playing. And playing for me was like praying.

As I gained more confidence in the inter-school and club circuit, any fear of failure began to disappear. My father had tried to instil fear in me about the uncertainty of the game. But you don't feel fear when you're in love. And I was in love with cricket.

My dream, my yardstick for success, was the one and only Khan: Imran. By the time I was in my teens, as he brought home the World Cup in 1992, I dreamt about being like him, his equal. I would pray to God and wonder: 'If Imran Khan has earned so much respect in the eyes of millions everywhere, why can't I? What is holding me back from becoming like him?'

My cricket fever was intense in those days. About three or four nights every week, before I slept, prior to any game or even at practice sessions, I dreamt with my eyes open. I visualized entire matches, all in my head – I'm walking into a stadium, the crowd is cheering, I'm slamming sixes…

I dreamt that I was the new Imran Khan.

I had no option but to dream. As a family, we weren't doing very well at the time. I financed my own cricket kit, bought my own shoes and did what I had to in order to keep playing cricket. There was little help from other members of the family. Sometimes I'd ask my elder brother for cash. Sometimes I'd steal a hundred or five hundred rupees (worth around one to five US dollars today, around twice as much then) from my father's wallet and use it to assemble my kit. Overall, it was a challenging phase in life. And those beatings … God, I don't think I'll ever forget them. It was passion alone that helped me survive and pursue cricket. Cricket was my fuel. It kept me going.

In those days, the 1990s, playing cricket at the U-14 level in the tough climate of Karachi was a unique experience. I used to sleep with my kit on so that I wouldn't be late for a match the following morning. My shoes would be just under the bed. I'd sleep with my socks on, even in summers, so that I didn't waste time trying to find them in the dark when I awoke at the crack of dawn.

It was in those days that I developed a habit I still struggle with: getting a good night's sleep before a big match. Even when I was captain, I'd arrive early at the ground, usually an hour before anyone else, and just soak in the atmosphere. Even looking at an empty ground helps you understand and plan what you will do. (This habit helped me throughout my career.)

After the morning games, I'd come home and shower and head out in the afternoon for another game, of tape-ball cricket, in the neighbourhood. In the evening, I'd wrap up play just in time to greet my father who would be back from work. To show him that I wasn't all that bad, I'd flip open my books and read aloud, just so that he didn't give me hell about not studying. This routine stuck for more than half the month during the school's calendar year.

The other half of the month was a bit more intense and I would break a few rules. After dark, when everyone at home was in bed, I'd sneak out and jump over the walls of our house to take part in the best part of Karachi cricket – late-night tape-ball tournaments, the pride of Karachi. This was my life: I'd sneak out, play the night match, come back at around four in the morning, exhausted, then wake up at seven for school, and then play the day matches.

It was madness. And I was mad. Cricket mad.